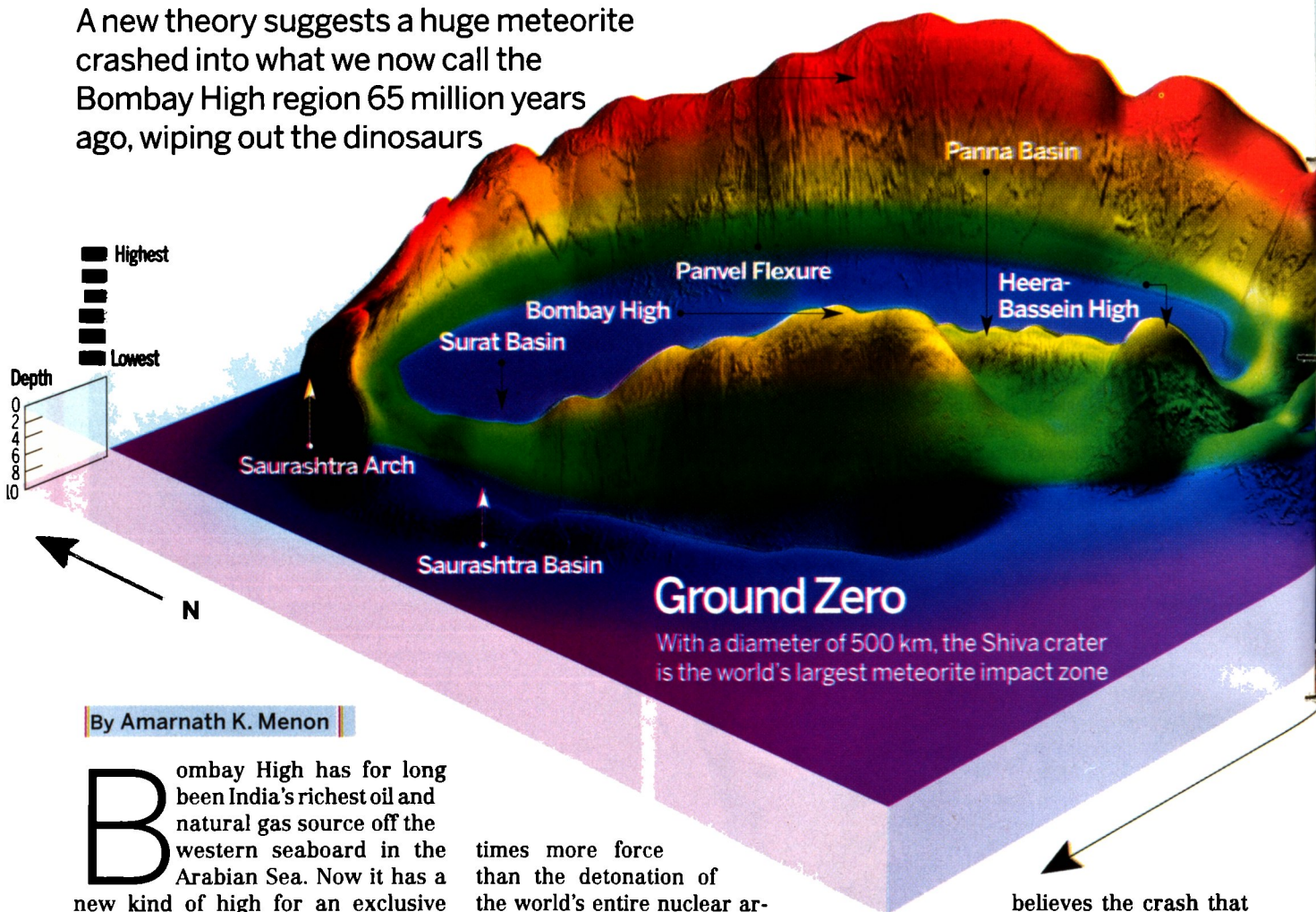


The Third EYE

A new theory suggests a huge meteorite crashed into what we now call the Bombay High region 65 million years ago, wiping out the dinosaurs



By Amarnath K. Menon

Bombay High has for long been India's richest oil and natural gas source off the western seaboard in the Arabian Sea. Now it has a new kind of high for an exclusive breed of Earth scientists called paleontologists who think that what lies beneath holds the clue to how life evolved on Earth, including the so far unexplained mass extinction of dinosaurs. The theory, which is gaining wider recognition, is propounded by Kolkata-born Texas Tech University geoscientist Sankar Chatterjee who presents a spectacular scenario of a meteorite, 40 km wide, crashing some 65 million years ago into where Bombay High exists today. The explosion caused in its wake had 10,000

times more force than the detonation of the world's entire nuclear arsenal. It created tsunamis and massive volcanic eruptions that blotted sunlight for close to a year and killed half the known species, including dinosaurs, that existed then. Chatterjee postulates that the impact created a gigantic crater as high as Mount Everest, though now under water, and has named it Shiva after the Hindu deity of creation and destruction.

"This is not from the storyboard of a science fiction thriller but what we have understood and gathered on ground zero," asserts Chatterjee. He

believes the crash that created it may have been the cause of the mass extinction called the K-T (Cretaceous-Tertiary) event. His argument runs counter to the widely held belief of what was behind the cataclysm. Many scientists have attributed the dinosaur extinction to the Chicxulub Crater off the coast of Mexico's Yucatan Peninsula. But some scientists at the Princeton University, USA, recently refuted this theory because evidence showed that the meteor struck 3,00,000 years before the demise of the dinosaurs.